

playlist formats like PLS, M3U, ASX, WAX and WVX.

Unlike media players, the Radio Tray sits in your menu bar and unobtrusively streams Internet radio for your listening pleasure.

Now make phone calls from Gmail

Gmail users can now make calls to home phones and mobile phones directly from their e-mail. Dialling a phone number works just like a normal phone. Just click Call at the top of your chat list and dial a number or enter a contact's name.

Calls to the US and Canada will be free for at least the rest of the year and calls to other countries will be billed at very low rates. "We worked hard to make these rates really cheap with calls to the UK, France, Germany, China, Japan—and many more countries—for as little as \$0.02 per minute," said Google.

The new Google service, as per analysts, poses a bigger competitive threat to services like Skype than to traditional phone companies. Skype users have been making calls from computers to phones for a long time. With over 560 million registered users, Skype is the most successful Internet phone offering.

Virtual router that transmits data at 40 GB/s

Researchers at the Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology have developed a networking router that transmits data at nearly 40 gigabytes (GB) per second—many times faster than the previous record for such a device.

Most routers use custom hardware to route data between computer networks. Software routers do this using commodity hardware—by mimicking the behaviour of a hardware router in software.

The PacketShader software developed by the researchers uses a computer's graphics processing unit

to help process packets of data sent across a network. And it could lead to a number of breakthroughs.

"We can expect killer apps out of this," says a professor at the Korea Advanced Institute of Science and Technology who was involved in the project. "You can build an interesting packet- or network-management system on top of a PC-based software router that can't be implemented with a hardware router. Ultimately, you can experiment with new protocols that are not used in today's Internet."

Robot-run household in Bengaluru

Ramaprasanna Chellamuthu, a developer evangelist for Microsoft, has his home overrun by robots in Bengaluru. These robots do a variety of tasks from waking him up to cleaning his house to alerting him of intruders in the house.

Unlike the uncanny humanoid variety, these robots are little convenience machines, each custom-made to serve a purpose.

Chellamuthu has been designing

the robots over weekends for five-six years, and in the past few months, has connected them to a cloud and to the Internet for an integrated 'buddyHome,'—a system that uses already available face- and image-recognition technology to offer intelligent everyday solutions. All of it cost just a few hundred rupees to him.

Chellamuthu says buddyHome is a self-learning system that takes three pictures of him every second, processes them to understand whether he's sleeping or smiling and activates certain features accordingly, recollecting all the information from the cloud—based on Windows Azure, Microsoft's cloud platform—at night to perform better each day.

Ration cards to go biometric

Very soon, ration cards in India may go hi-tech with integration of the biometric technology. This will help make ration cards foolproof identity documents and curb the problem of bogus ration cards.

The Maharashtra government has announced a programme that will utilise the biometric data collected under the central government's unique identity cards (UID) scheme and incorporate this data into the ration cards to transform these into biometric identity documents. The data collected for UID, like photo of a person, fingerprints and iris image, would be used for the biometric ration cards as the data requirement is similar.

The data collection for the UID project will begin on 1st November and is likely to complete by February 2011. This data will then be sourced by the Food and Civil Supplies Department to make the biometric ration cards.



Ramaprasanna Chellamuthu's buddyHome

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